

CUCUMBERS *Cucumis sativus*

You can grow a cucumber no matter how small your garden: if you have limited space, grow a trailing outdoor variety in a container. Outdoor cucumbers are hardier than their indoor relatives, with a thicker, more knobbled skin, and are excellent pickled. If you have the luxury of a greenhouse, you can grow indoor varieties, too, which are longer, with thinner skins, and are good for use in salads or sandwiches.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
SOW/PLANT				
HARVEST				

SOWING

Most modern greenhouse varieties are all-female and it is important that they are grown where they cannot be pollinated by male flowers, since this results in bitter fruits. Site plants carefully, and pinch out any male flowers that appear on indoor types.

Outdoor cucumbers grow best in a warm, sunny site, and will thrive in containers or growing bags, indoors or out. They need a rich, well-drained soil, so dig in well-rotted manure or compost before sowing or planting out.

Seed can be sown indoors from early spring onward; it needs a minimum temperature of 68°F (20°C) to germinate. Harden off and plant out seedlings when they reach about four weeks old,



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taking care not to damage the roots. Space them 18 in (45 cm) apart, allowing more room if plants are to trail.

Alternatively, warm the soil with a cloche or cold frame and sow directly into the ground from early summer, once the danger of frosts has passed. Sow two or three seeds together every 18 in (45 cm) and thin out the weakest as they develop.